

Cooler Master X Craft 250

A cool data companion!

External casings are widely used with laptop hard drives as portable data transfer solutions. The X Craft 250 is an eSATA/USB casing from Cooler Master; it promises to keep high-capacity laptop hard drives cool.

Crafted in aluminium, the core design objective, like we said, is good thermal dissipation. The meshed screen running along two sides takes care of ventilation. The white paint provides a quality finish, as also decent fingerprint resistance.

Power-hungry laptop drives are addressed by the use of split USB cables. The eSATA connectivity makes for a high 3Gb/s transfer rate.

The USB cable or the 5V DC jack is used to power

the case in the eSATA mode.

Cooler Master provides rubber grommets for attaching the hard drive to the PCB—a nifty touch; it also provides shock resistance. Mounting the hard drive is quite easy; also, Cooler Master has been generous enough to provide a little screw driver, screws, and the grommets.

For our test, we used the WD SATA 250 GB 2500BEVS as the internal drive. The results were quite competitive. A 0.7 ms access time in SiSoft



Sandra, along with a 17.8 ms random access time in HD Tach, highlights the fact that the internal

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Ease of Use	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

controller will not be a bottleneck in the drive's throughput. In the real-world 1 GB assorted test, the drive took 63 / 47 / 89 seconds (to / from / within). In the case of sequential 1 GB single-file transfer, the drive took 45 / 36 / 84 seconds (to / from / within). Transferring 1 GB of assorted files simultaneously to and from took 83 seconds.

The package bundle consists of the drive, a nice pouch, and the necessary backup software. We think it's a good buy.

Specifications

Dimensions: 81 x 19 x 136 mm (W x H x D); weight: 140 gm; interface: USB 2.0/1.1; eSATA

Contact: SMC International

Phone: 98100 26658

Email: himanshu@

amigointernational.biz

Web site: www.coolermaster.com

Price: Rs 1,560 (plus taxes)

Bose Companion 5

Class on your desk

The satellites on the Bose Companion 5—hereon referred to as the BC 5—look like a prop from a *Star Wars* film set. However, the long subwoofer looks a little like a largish UPS. The matte-finished black and grey looks elegant, and the stylish satellites and classy control pod all add up to a killer designer-desk!

A word on the round control pod—a tap on the middle and the speakers switch on, another tap—off. The volume control operation is also ultra-slick. It also features a headphone jack and an auxiliary in (for portable media players, for example).

The BC 5 connects via USB and not a 3.5 mm jack. And this is the good and the bad part of this set (you decide which!). Good: you've got an inbuilt sound solution (no sound card required), which doesn't even require a driver under Windows XP. This, coupled with the proprietary TrueSpace surround digital processing, gives you virtual surround sound from a stereo speaker set. Bad: if you have a good sound card capable of better sound.

We listened to a few of our favourite tunes and the mandatory test tracks on the BC 5 for a day. The first gripe is the subwoofer—the bass is “boomy,” too much so for our liking. Second, the bass doesn't have that classy wooden feel to it. On a positive note, the satellites are definitely punchy, and will happily outdo the bundled bass unit if allowed to.



The sound from the satellites is particularly mellow in the mids.

DVD movies will benefit from this kind of bass; audiophiles with their music will hate it. The sound really does seem to surround you; whatever acoustic technology Bose has put to work is evidently doing its job—though it's not as good as a discrete 5.1 setup.

At Rs 21,000, the BC 5 is costly. You get indisputably great looks and sometimes disputably good sound. Bose builds lifestyle products for

the flamboyant, who pay as much for the show as for the go. If you fit the bill, and can stomach it—buy the BC 5. If you're not part of that minority, skip this one.

Specifications

Amplified 2.1 system; interface: USB; wired control pod unit; auxiliary in and headphone connects

Contact: Bose Corporation India

Pvt Ltd

Phone: 1-800-11-2673

E-mail: NA

Web site: www.boseindia.com

Price: Rs 21,900

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Build Quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆